

In-Class Grant Review Simulation

Adapted from the AZA Conservation Grants Fund Reviewer Evaluation Form

Overview

In this in-class activity, you will act as reviewers for **redacted AZA Conservation Grants Fund (CGF)** proposals.

Your task is to **assess proposal quality, feasibility, and impact** using the same criteria AZA reviewers apply when determining which conservation projects to fund.

This simulation mirrors a real-world grant panel process, helping you:

- Evaluate conservation proposals critically and professionally.
- Recognize how reviewers weigh scientific merit, feasibility, and conservation significance.
- Practice consensus decision-making with peers.

Instructions

1. You will be given **four redacted CGF proposals** to review.
2. First, read your two assigned proposals individually and complete the **Detailed Reviewer Evaluation Form** below (15–20 minutes).
3. Next, skim the other two proposals so that you are prepared to discuss your teammates' assessment. (5-10 minutes).
4. Then, work as a team to compare scores and reach a **panel recommendation** (25–30 minutes).

Detailed Reviewer Evaluation A

Proposal Title: _____

Reviewer Name: _____

Evaluation and Comments

Please answer each question concisely. These responses are for internal scoring and discussion, not for sharing with applicants.

Conservation Significance

- Explain how well the project addresses a critical conservation or management need.
- Does it align with AZA priorities (e.g., SAFE species, One Plan Approach, sustainability of managed populations)?

Goals and Objectives

- Are the one-year goals, objectives, and proposed actions clear and achievable?
- Do they logically support a meaningful long-term conservation outcome?

Methods, Monitoring, and Evaluation

- Are the proposed methods appropriate and feasible?
- Does the project have a clear plan for assessing progress and outcomes?

Budget Appropriateness

- Is the proposed budget reasonable for the scope of work?
- Are major costs justified?

Overall Strengths and Weaknesses

- Identify key strengths and weaknesses in design, feasibility, or impact.

Overall Rating

Using the scale below, rate the overall quality of this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Detailed Reviewer Evaluation B

Proposal Title: _____

Reviewer Name: _____

Evaluation and Comments

Please answer each question concisely. These responses are for internal scoring and discussion, not for sharing with applicants.

Conservation Significance

- Explain how well the project addresses a critical conservation or management need.
- Does it align with AZA priorities (e.g., SAFE species, One Plan Approach, sustainability of managed populations)?

Goals and Objectives

- Are the one-year goals, objectives, and proposed actions clear and achievable?
- Do they logically support a meaningful long-term conservation outcome?

Methods, Monitoring, and Evaluation

- Are the proposed methods appropriate and feasible?
- Does the project have a clear plan for assessing progress and outcomes?

Budget Appropriateness

- Is the proposed budget reasonable for the scope of work?
- Are major costs justified?

Overall Strengths and Weaknesses

- Identify key strengths and weaknesses in design, feasibility, or impact.

Overall Rating

Using the scale below, rate the overall quality of this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Panel Summary

After completing individual reviews, collaborate in your small group to summarize your consensus review.

Resource Allocation

Your goal is to maximize your annual organizational budget toward advancing One Plan oriented conservation with maximum impact. You have a **budget of up to \$35,000 to award**, and you may distribute this across as many awards as you choose. You may choose to reduce some awards below the requested budget (but do so carefully with project feasibility and output in mind). The table below provides some examples of the ways you might approach your budget allocation for this grant.

Allocation Strategy	Projects Funded	Total Spent
Fund one proposal fully (e.g., \$23,000) and one partially (\$12,000)	2	\$35,000
Fund three smaller projects at reduced levels (\$15,000 + \$10,000 + \$10,000)	3	\$35,000
Fund only the strongest single proposal at full amount (\$23,000) and reserve balance for future cycle	1	\$23,000
Distribute moderate partial awards across all proposals (e.g., \$10,000 each)	4	\$40,000 (<i>over budget—requires cuts elsewhere</i>)
Provide two full awards and one honorable mention (no funds)	3 (2 funded)	\$34,000

Group Members: _____

Proposal 1

Proposal Title: _____

Consensus Rating

Using the scale below, provide a final rating for this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Award Decision

- ☐ **Full Award**
- ☐ **Partial Award**
- ☐ **Honorable Mention**
- ☐ **Do Not Fund**

Amount Awarded: _____

Proposal 2

Proposal Title: _____

Consensus Rating

Using the scale below, provide a final rating for this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Award Decision

- ☐ Full Award
- ☐ Partial Award
- ☐ Honorable Mention
- ☐ Do Not Fund

Amount Awarded: _____

Proposal 3

Proposal Title: _____

Consensus Rating

Using the scale below, provide a final rating for this proposal.

- ☐ 5 Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ 4 Strong proposal and project
- ☐ 3 Average proposal and project
- ☐ 2 Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ 1 Weak proposal and project

Award Decision

- ☐ Full Award
- ☐ Partial Award
- ☐ Honorable Mention
- ☐ Do Not Fund

Amount Awarded: _____

Proposal 4

Proposal Title: _____

Consensus Rating

Using the scale below, provide a final rating for this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Award Decision

- ☐ **Full Award**
- ☐ **Partial Award**
- ☐ **Honorable Mention**
- ☐ **Do Not Fund**

Amount Awarded: _____

Synthesis

Amount Spent: _____ **Number of Projects Funded:** _____

Rationale

Summarize why your group reached its decision.
